

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action

2026 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Majdi Gaith

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council 4th District

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including a San Pablo Specific Plan and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- San Pablo specific plan
- Zoning for housing in high-resource commercial areas like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave
- Extending 'middle housing' zoning to some parts of the Hills, while balancing fire risk
- Other strategies for Berkeley to affirmatively further fair housing

I support Berkeley meeting its housing goals, but the Housing Element must be implemented in a way that creates permanently affordable homes and protects existing residents from displacement. We cannot just build luxury units and call it progress.

For San Pablo, I support a specific plan that includes deeply affordable housing, union labor, community benefits, and protections for existing small businesses. San Pablo has been underinvested in for decades. New housing there should serve the people already living and working in the area.

For North Shattuck, Solano, and College, I support upzoning only where it includes strong affordable housing requirements and protections for the small businesses that make those corridors thrive. Upzoning should not mean displacement.

For middle housing in the Hills, I am open to modest changes but fire risk and evacuation safety must be taken seriously. Any upzoning there must include wildfire safety standards and infrastructure planning.

To affirmatively further fair housing, Berkeley must invest in social housing, community land trusts, tenant right to counsel, and Black and brown homeownership support. We also need to dismantle the lingering effects of redlining by building affordable housing in high resource neighborhoods, not just in the flatlands.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

I support the Climate Action Plan goals, but the city is not moving fast enough. The two biggest sources of emissions are cars and gas appliances. Both need bold action.

I support building electrification, municipal clean energy, and stronger incentives for retrofits in older buildings. I also support bringing back an electrification approach at the local level as far as state law allows.

On transportation, I support free or low cost public transit for youth and low income riders, safer crosswalks, protected bike lanes where they work, and pedestrian first streets. I support an all of the above transit strategy.

The most important thing we can do is make it easier and cheaper for working families to live without relying on gas cars and gas appliances. Climate action cannot be a luxury for wealthy homeowners.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's

decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The most consequential vote was the decision to allow a five percent rent increase under Measure BB instead of the lower three percent increase recommended by the Rent Board and Berkeley Tenants Union. My opponent was the decisive fifth vote for the higher increase.

This vote mattered because it directly raised costs for thousands of renters at a time when affordability was already a crisis. I would have voted for the lower increase. I would also have tied any increase to stronger tenant protections and a real vacancy tax.

Housing policy is not just about building. It is also about keeping people in their homes. This vote showed whose side the current council is on.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The most important issue was the fight over building electrification and the city's natural gas ban that was struck down. Berkeley tried to lead on electrification and got punished by a federal court. That does not mean the city should retreat. It means we need to fight differently.

I would support public education, stronger incentives, and local codes that push electrification as far as legally possible. I would also push for a public power utility so Berkeley does not have to rely on PG&E for clean energy progress.

Climate action requires persistence. The current council talks about climate goals but has not moved fast enough on building emissions and transit.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

New housing must be built near transit and designed to reduce car dependence. That means more density near BART and major bus lines, with fewer parking requirements and better walking and biking infrastructure.

I support free or low cost transit, protected bike lanes, bike parking in new buildings, and car share spaces. New developments should include transit passes for residents and strong all electric standards.

Growth and climate action are not opposites. The problem is car dependent sprawl, not dense walkable neighborhoods. If we build the right way, we can add homes and reduce emissions at the same time.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets?

Safety is the first requirement for getting people out of cars. If people don't feel safe walking or biking, they won't do it.

I support lower speeds on neighborhood streets, better crosswalks, protected intersections, and traffic calming near schools and parks. I also support daylighting intersections and safer bike routes that connect to schools, transit, and commercial areas.

I support bike lanes where they work. I opposed the Hopkins bike lane as designed because it removed roughly 145 parking spaces and hurt small businesses. We need safe streets and thriving businesses. Those should not be in conflict.

The city should also fix sidewalks and curb ramps so seniors and people with disabilities can move safely.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

I support inclusionary zoning, but I do not think it is enough by itself. The Turner Center research is important. If we set the requirements too high or make the rules unstable, we slow down all housing production, including affordable housing.

I support a balanced approach. Inclusionary units should be required, but we should also use in lieu fees wisely to fund social housing and community land trusts. The in lieu fees must actually produce affordable units, not just sit in a fund.

Berkeley should also build public housing directly through a social housing authority. That is the surest way to create permanently affordable homes without relying on private developers.

On site affordable housing is important for integration. But social housing and land trusts do more to remove housing from the speculative market forever. We need both.